# Written Document

Five steps with guiding questions to help you understand and analyze the primary source

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| **1** **Identify the Source** | When was this document created? |
| | Where was it created? |
| | Who wrote the document? |
| **2** **Place the Source in Context** | What was the historical context for this document? Is it associated with an event or movement? |
| | Who was the intended audience for this document? |
| | What kind of document is it? How would you categorize it? |
| | How was this document distributed? Was there one copy made, or many copies? |
| | Was the creation of this document an unusual event, or something done regularly? |
| **3** **Analyze the Source Content** | What is the subject of this document? What issue or issues does it address? What information is conveyed? |
| | What arguments does the author or authors of this document make? |
| **4** **Assess the Source Perspective** | Does this document have a particular perspective or bias? |
| | What type of language is used in this document? |
| | How do you think people at the time reacted to this document? |
| **5** **Evaluate the Source** | Do you think this document is an effective one? |
| | Why is this document important? Why was it important to the people or institution who created it, and why is important now for what it can tell us? |
| | What connections can you make from this document to politics, issues, culture and society, faith and religion, historical change over time, etc.? |
| | Does comparing this document with other sources, past or present, provide valuable insight? |
| | How can you tie this document into key themes, questions, controversies, and debates? |